Preparing Purpose-Ready Graduates for an AI-Augmented Workforce:

A Cross-Functional Model for Recruiting, Academic Pathways, & Career Readiness

Lisa Keegan
lakeegan01@wm.edu
Vice Provost for Enrollment Strategies

Douglas C. Schmidt
dcschmidt@wm.edu
Dean of Computing, Data Sciences & Physics

Kathleen Powell
kipowell@wm.edu
Chief Career Officer

AI is Rewriting Student Demand, Academic Preparation, & Career Outcomes

PREPARING PURPOSE-READY GRADUATES FOR THE AGE OF AI

STUDENT DEMAND

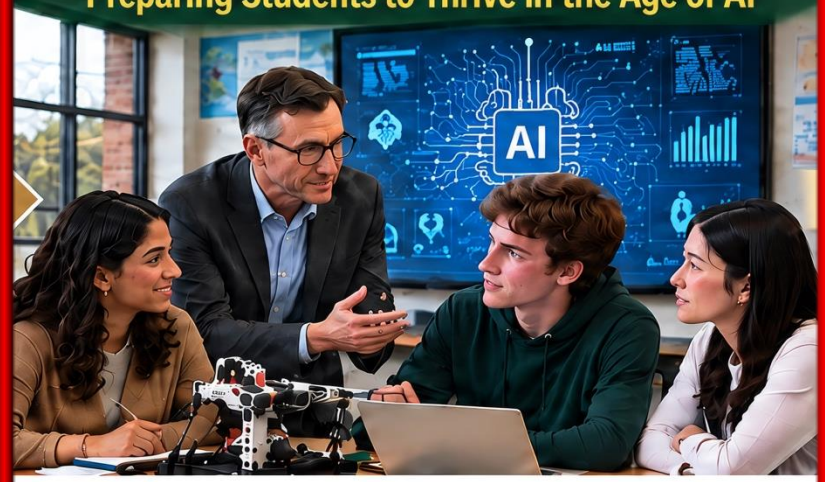
A More Discerning, Opportunity-Seeking Generation



- Relevant, future-ready education
- Meaningful opportunities and experiences
- Real-world impact
- Strong career prospects

ACADEMIC EXCELLENCE + RESEARCH & INNOVATION

Preparing Students to Thrive in the Age of AI



- AI-infused curriculum and interdisciplinary pathways
- Accelerated bachelor's-to-master's options
- Undergraduate research and innovation
- Experiential learning, internships, and real-world projects

GRADUATE & ALUMNI OUTCOMES

Purpose-Ready Graduates for an AI-Augmented Workforce



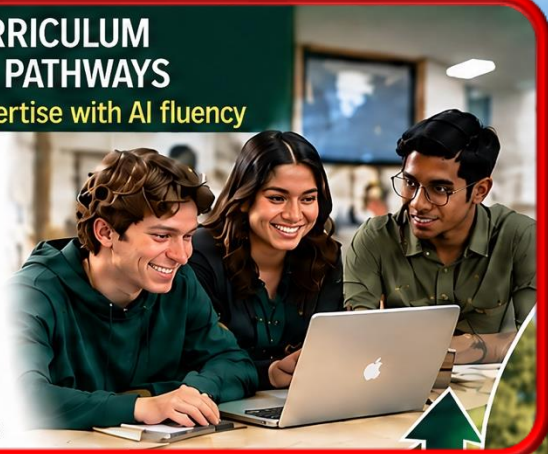
- Strong career preparation and digital readiness
- High graduation and employment outcomes
- Engaged alumni and employer networks
- Graduates who lead, innovate, and create positive impact

Building Purpose-Ready Graduates Thru Curriculum, Research, & Applied Learning

Preparing Purpose-Ready Graduates for the Age of AI

1 AI-Infused Curriculum and Academic Pathways
Build disciplinary expertise with AI fluency

- Integrate AI across disciplines
- Teach ethical and responsible use
- Interdisciplinary pathways
- Prepare for real-world challenges



2 Accelerated Bachelor's-to-Master's Pathways
Deepen expertise and expand opportunities

- Streamlined pathways
- Flexible program options
- Meet workforce demand
- Access to high-impact careers





Purpose-Ready Graduates

Disciplinary depth | Ethical judgment
Real-world experience | AI fluency

3 Experiential Learning and Internship Ecosystems
Apply knowledge in real-world settings

- Internships, workbased learning, and co-ops
- Hands-on projects
- Industry and government partnerships
- Practical skills and professional growth



4 Undergraduate Research Engagement
Create, discover, and innovate

- Cutting-edge research
- Real-world problem solving
- Faculty mentorship
- Meaningful societal impact



5 Digital Communication and AI-Mediated Hiring Preparation
Communicate, compete, and lead in an AI-enabled workplace

- Communicate with impact
- Prepare for digital interviews
- Showcase your work
- Use AI responsibly and effectively



From Preparation to Outcomes: Making AI Readiness Visible

CURRICULUM

AI-infused coursework across disciplines with ethics and human judgment.



RESEARCH

Solve real-world problems and drive innovation.



EXPERIENCE

Internships, applied learning, and real-world projects.



SKILLS

Build digital and communication skills, including effective use of AI.



PREPARING PURPOSE-READY GRADUATES FOR THE AGE OF AI



- Meaningful Employment
- Graduate Education
- Lifelong Learning
- Civic Leadership

Synergizing Student & Employer Demand to Move at the Speed of Need



1. STUDENT & FAMILY DEMAND

What Students and Families Are Seeking

- Future-ready, relevant education
- Clear value and return on investment
- Meaningful experiences and impact
- A clear path to rewarding careers

DEMAND SIGNALS INFORM ACADEMIC INNOVATION

STRONGER OUTCOMES ATTRACT MORE STUDENTS

STRONGER, MORE RELEVANT UNIVERSITIES

Preparing purpose-ready graduates for an AI-augmented workforce

2. ACADEMIC PROGRAMS & PATHWAYS

What We Build



- AI-infused curriculum across disciplines
- New and flexible programs and pathways (e.g., BMAPs)
- Undergraduate research and innovation
- Experiential learning and real-world projects

3. EMPLOYER & ALUMNI INSIGHTS

What Employers and Alumni Say Graduates Need



- AI-ready, adaptable talent
- Strong problem-solving and communication skills
- Practical experience and portfolio evidence.
- Ethical, responsible, and effective use of AI

Discussion Question #1

- **How Do We Break Down Institutional Silos to Prepare Purpose-Ready Graduates?**
  - What would change if faculty, academic leadership, enrollment management, career services, & employer partners jointly designed the student experience rather than pursuing separate initiatives?
  - What practical barriers must we overcome?

Discussion Question #2

- **Are We Preparing Students for the Workforce They're Actually Entering?**
  - As AI transforms entry-level jobs & employer expectations, what skills, experiences, & human capabilities must our graduates demonstrate to succeed—& where are our current educational approaches falling short?

Discussion Question #3

- **Where Are the Biggest Gaps in Our Student Success Ecosystem?**
  - Across AI-infused curricula, accelerated degree pathways, experiential learning, undergraduate research, & career preparation, which opportunities are we missing—& what prevents us from connecting these experiences into a coherent student journey?

Discussion Question #4

- **What One Action Could We Take in the Next 90 Days?**
  - If you could launch one cross-functional initiative to better prepare students for an AI-augmented workforce, what would it be, who would need to participate, & how would you measure whether it improves student learning or career readiness?

